

RAIDERS OF the Lost Art



37 sculptures and idols from 17 temple sites stolen between 2005 and 2008

1,000 cr per year is the value of India's legal contemporary art market

13,230 monument attendants are needed, but there are only 3,463

In the absence of effective laws, artworks continue to disappear from temples and museums only to turn into international commodities

By Nishika Patel

The next time you are marveling at the world heritage site of Khajuraho, don't do a double-take if you find a Shiva sculpture missing. One of the seven wonders of India has fallen prey to idol thieves. The most high-profile cases in recent years include the theft of Rabindranath Tagore's Nobel Prize medal along with his pocket watch and father's gold ring from a West Bengal university in 2004. A UK auction house recently sparked a controversy over the sale of a George Cross medal, allegedly stolen from the home of an Indian Army veteran. These are not isolated cases. Temples and museums across India have been looted of precious idols, antiquities and medals, some of which have found their way to foreign auction houses and private museums. The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), in charge of guarding the country's monuments and antiquities, says more than 37 sculptures and

Lost and Rarely Found

Stolen Item : George Cross Medal

Stolen From : Brahmi Devi's home in Himachal Pradesh

Found: At UK auction house

Status: The auction was stopped at Dix Noonan Web following the claim by Devi that it was her husband Naik Kripa Ram's medal, awarded to him in 1946 and stolen in 2002

